

pan, New National Curriculum and Pedagogical framework, National Foundational Literacy, and Numeracy Mission. In order to boost the Skill India Mission, two new schemes, Skills Acquisition and Knowledge Awareness for Livelihood Promotion (SANKALP) and Skill Strengthening for Industrial Value Enhancement (STRIVE), have been approved by the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA), government of India, with an outlay of 66.55 billion rupees. These will be supported by the World Bank.

By the end of 2021, India's e-learning capacity would have basked in a steady growth rate of 25 per cent each year and become a 1.96 billion dollars industry. According to a report by KPMG, in India, the edtech industry stood at 247 million dollars in 2016 and is expected to reach 1.96 billion dollars by the end of 2021. Backed by the Digital India initiative, the Ministry of Human Resource Development (MHRD) has offered various schemes and initiatives to perk-up edtech industry, such as E-Yantra, virtual lab, Free and Open Source Software for Education (FOSSEE), National Digital Library (NDL), SWAYAM and SWAYAM Prabha.

Current obstructions to the edtech market

In the ongoing Covid-19 pandemic, the economy has crippled globally but, at the same time, everything has gone online, even in the education sector, where electronic gadgets and

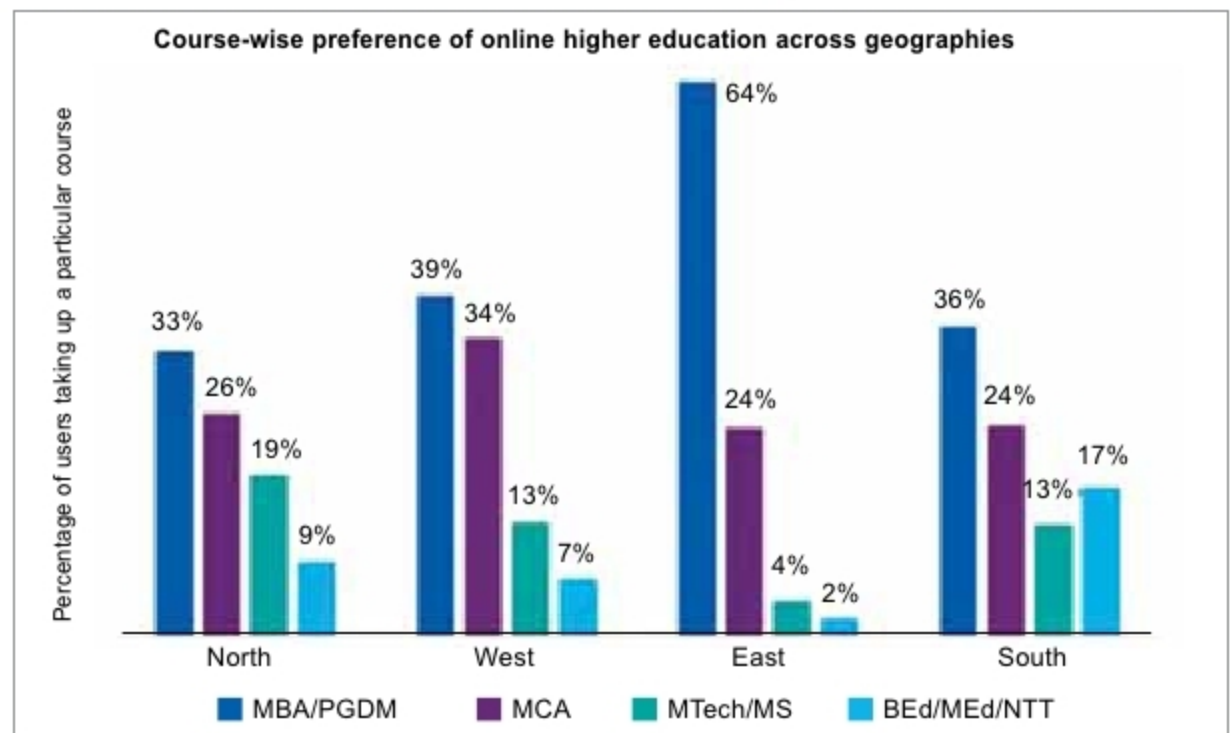


Fig. 3: Online education in India: 2021 (Source: KPMG report)

technology are playing an extremely crucial role to boost the sector. tecARC believes that like any other sector, digital has become the backbone of the education sector. No assessment has been done yet, but as per observation, every school has become digital, at least in the private sector.

ICA Edu Skills have highlighted several challenges in an exclusive conversation with EFY Media. These are as follows:

Content. Both digital and physical education have their own pros and cons. It's slightly difficult to state it with a number of data. We are still seeing a lot of traditional courses that were relevant decades ago and are prevalent even today. So, how can we have a better digital learning

experience? If we see, the syllabus of B.Com in India hasn't changed in a decade. The engineering syllabus has only been modified a little. Thus, we need to change our content. We need to invest a lot of time, energy, and brains into developing content that is relevant in today's times. This is really important.

Connectivity. Though Internet data packs have become affordable, still, there are many places where connectivity is poor. Although, we believe that this issue is already being addressed at a good pace by telecom giants like Jio.

Hardware. When we speak about digital education, it does not mean just mobile phones. Our country has one of the lowest penetrations of laptops and personal computers in the world. With digital education gaining popularity, these electronic gadgets need to be made available, especially to those people who cannot afford. This can only happen with government intervention.

Skilling. We have heard this term being used by a lot of political figures, stating its importance for the nation's growth, removing poverty, and making the country self-reliant, right since independence. However, we still have a long way to go. A huge allocation of funds is the demand of the hour so that skilling can reach every young individual in our country. Currently, there is no such major project that addresses the skilling and training needs of our youth digitally. **EFY**

Experts' views on the role of technology in Indian education

"India is the second most populated country in the world. And, we have always heard about the demographic dividend that we can get from this population. But this demographic dividend can only be encashed in GDP terms if this population is educated, skilled, and trained, thereby adding value to our country's economy. This can only happen with a proper skilling ecosystem in place. The Covid-19 pandemic has changed everything right from how we live, work, interact, eat, study, or spend our money. Times are changing, and so are the demands. What was relevant or in high demand ten years ago probably doesn't make any sense now. One needs to update their skills accordingly. That's why the most important time is 'now' to focus more than ever on how to take advantage of this digital wave to improve our education system. Only then we can reap the benefit of this demographic dividend. 'Digital' offers a unique solution to reach every deserving candidate in any part of the country. With proper skilling and training, we can minimise unemployment and achieve the dream of a self-reliant country."

—Ankit Shyamsukha, CEO, ICA Edu Skills

"The uneven development in the country has led to the uneven allocation of resources. So, what is available to people dwelling in metros and Tier 1 cities, isn't available elsewhere. Digital initiatives can considerably fill up this gap. So, professionals as well as students can get access to the best of education and skills to excel in their careers. We may have differences in infrastructure, but we cannot deprive students and professionals in Tier 2 and 3 cities and towns of the latest industry expectations."

—Faisal Kawoosa, founder, techARC